MODULE 08 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Virtual, distributed and diverse teams

Leading people across distance, time zones, cultures and languages, and making different perspectives an advantage.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 08 of 49

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Distance does not break teams. Unspoken assumptions do.

Kinds of team arrangement

ARRANGEMENT	WHAT IT MEANS	MAIN CHALLENGE
Co-located	Everyone in one place	Little, except space and noise
Distributed	Several sites, often in different countries	Time zones, culture, handoffs
Fully remote	Everyone works from separate locations	Trust, isolation, informal contact
Hybrid	Some in the office, some remote, varying by day	Fairness between the two groups

ON THE EXAM

Hybrid is often the hardest. Two groups form without anyone intending it.

Virtual teams: what you gain and what you lose

GAINS

Reach and flexibility

- Access to scarce skills anywhere
- Lower travel and office costs
- Flexible working for people
- Follow-the-sun coverage

LOSSES

Signal and connection

- Fewer informal conversations
- Less body language and context
- Time-zone gaps delay answers
- Isolation and weaker trust

THE TIEBREAKER

The losses are real but predictable. Good answers deliberately replace what distance removes.

Synchronous or asynchronous?

MODE	EXAMPLES	USE IT FOR
Synchronous	Video calls, phone, live workshops	Relationships, conflict, complex decisions, feedback
Asynchronous	Chat, shared documents, recorded demos, virtual boards	Updates, status, reference information, across time zones

ON THE EXAM

Updates can wait for the reader. Relationships and disagreements need people present at the same time.

Working across time zones

- Find the **overlap window** and protect it for work that needs everyone live.
- **Rotate** inconvenient meeting times, so the same people do not always suffer.
- Move routine updates to **asynchronous** channels, and record every decision where all can see it.
- Always scheduling for the largest or most senior group quietly excludes everyone else.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Fairness across time zones is agreed with the team, and written into the working agreement.

Extra working agreements for distributed teams

- **Core hours** and the overlap window each person commits to.
- **Response times** by channel: urgent by phone, routine within a stated time.
- **Where decisions live**, so nobody relies on memory of a call.
- **Calendars** of local holidays and working weeks, which differ by country.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The team charter from module 07 matters twice as much when people are apart. Add these to it.

Building trust at a distance

- Meet in person at the start if at all possible. Early relationships carry the team through later strain.
- Use video for relationship conversations, and keep regular **one-to-ones**.
- Make time for **informal contact**: virtual coffee, a social channel, team-building.
- **Recognise** contributions visibly, so remote work is not invisible work.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Trust grows from contact and reliability. At a distance, both have to be designed in.

Match the channel to the message

MESSAGE	BEST CHANNEL
Performance concern, conflict, bad news	Face to face, or a private video call
Complex problem needing discussion	Video call or live workshop
Quick question, coordination	Chat or phone
Decision record, formal notice, detail	Written: email or a shared document

ON THE EXAM

The more emotional or complex the message, the richer the channel it needs.

Cultural differences that show up at work

- **Directness**: some cultures say 'no' plainly; others signal it gently.
- **Hierarchy**: in some, disagreeing with a senior person openly is uncomfortable.
- **Context**: some rely on explicit words, others on relationship and setting.
- Learn the norms, **ask rather than assume**, and avoid judging one style as right.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Silence in a meeting may not mean agreement. Create other ways for people to raise concerns.

Working across languages

- Use **plain language**. Avoid idioms, jokes and acronyms that do not travel.
- **Follow up in writing**, with examples, after important verbal agreements.
- **Check understanding** by asking people to play back what they heard, not 'is that clear?'.
- 'Yes' on a call may mean 'I heard you', not 'I agree' or 'I understood'.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Misunderstanding across languages is prevented by playback and written examples, not by longer calls.

Diversity as an advantage

- The outline asks you to **support the team's varied experiences, skills and perspectives**.
- Diverse teams spot more risks and more options, if everyone's view actually gets heard.
- Use **round-robin** input, silent brainstorming or anonymous tools so quieter voices count.
- Use **inclusive language**, which the Agile Practice Guide's second edition emphasises throughout.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Diversity only helps when the process lets every perspective in. Design meetings for that.

Running fair hybrid meetings

- The trap: the room talks to itself, and remote people become an audience.
- **Remote-first**: if anyone is remote, everyone joins from their own device.
- Use one shared digital board and record decisions in one visible place.
- No decisions in the corridor afterwards. If it was not recorded, it was not decided.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Hybrid fairness is a design choice. Put everyone on the same footing, and decide only in the shared space.

Project Lantern at a distance

- The **kiosk supplier's engineers** work from another country, five hours ahead.
- The app team is **hybrid**: three in the Northgate office, four remote.
- Agreements: a daily two-hour overlap window, remote-first meetings, decisions logged in the project channel.
- Supplier specifications are confirmed in writing, with worked examples, after every design call.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Every agreement here makes an assumption explicit. That is the whole technique.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
One region always joins at an unsocial hour	Agree an overlap window; rotate; go asynchronous
Some members never raise concerns	Other channels: one-to-ones, anonymous, round-robin
Sensitive message to a remote colleague	Private video call, not email or chat
Remote members feel left out of decisions	Remote-first meetings; decisions recorded in one place
Work built to a different understanding	Written confirmation with examples; playback
New virtual team, little collaboration	Kickoff, team-building, a charter with norms

ON THE EXAM

In every case, make the unspoken explicit. None of these answers blames the distance.

> A team spans the UK, India and the USA. The daily coordination meeting is always held at a time that suits the US members, which is midnight in India.
>
> The India-based members have started turning their cameras off and contributing less.

What should the project manager do?

A Remind all members that attendance at the daily meeting is mandatory.

B Hold separate meetings for each region, without sharing the outcomes.

C Excuse the India-based members from the meeting and send them the minutes.

D Work with the team to agree an overlap window, rotate times, and move updates to asynchronous channels.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Attendance is mandatory.
Enforces the unfairness. Engagement will keep falling.

B Separate regional meetings, unshared.
Splits the team into silos with no coordination at all.

C Excuse them; send minutes.
Turns part of the team into readers of decisions made without them.

D Agree overlap, rotate, go asynchronous.
Fair, agreed with the team, and keeps everyone included.

THE SIGNAL

One group always carrying the inconvenience: agree fairness with the team.

> Several members of a multinational team come from cultures where openly disagreeing with senior colleagues is uncommon. They rarely speak in team meetings.
>
> Problems they were aware of have surfaced late twice, causing rework.

What should the project manager do?

A Tell these team members that they are expected to speak up in meetings.

B Learn about their norms, and create other ways to raise concerns, such as one-to-ones and anonymous input.

C Invite only senior team members to decision meetings to save time.

D Report the late problems to the team members' functional managers.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Tell them to speak up.
Asks people to act against deep norms, without making it any safer to do so.

B. Learn norms; open other channels.
Respects the culture and still gets the information out early.

C. Only seniors in decision meetings.
Removes exactly the people who know about the problems.

D. Report to their managers.
Punishes a cultural difference. Makes speaking up even less likely.

THE SIGNAL

Silence was not agreement. Change the channel, not the person.

> A remote team member's recent work has contained repeated errors, and a client has noticed. The project manager needs to raise it with him.
>
> He works from home, in the same time zone, and the project manager is drafting an email.

How should the project manager raise the issue?

A In a private video call.

B In a detailed email, so there is a written record.

C In a direct message in the team chat channel.

D During the team's weekly video call.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the project manager raise the issue?

A Private video call.

Rich, two-way and private: right for a sensitive performance conversation.

B Detailed email.

Loses tone, invites misreading, and gives no chance to understand the cause.

C Chat message.

Even thinner than email for a sensitive topic.

D The weekly team call.

Public. Performance is discussed privately.

THE SIGNAL

Sensitive and personal: the richest private channel available. A written note can follow.

> A new fully remote team of eight has been assembled from four organisations. Most members have never met.
>
> After a month, work is passed around by email, nobody asks each other for help, and several members say they feel isolated.

What should the project manager do?

A Increase the frequency of individual status reports.

B Assign each person a fixed area so they depend on each other less.

C Bring the team together for a kickoff and team-building, and agree working norms in a charter.

D Escalate the poor collaboration to the four organisations' managers.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. More status reports.
More reporting, no more connection. Isolation continues.

B. Reduce interdependence.
Avoids the problem, and turns a team into eight individuals.

C. Kickoff, team-building, a charter.
Builds the relationships and agreements the team never had.

D. Escalate to four sets of managers.
Nothing has been tried yet, and it is the PM's job to build the team.

THE SIGNAL

People who have never met, and feel isolated: build the team deliberately. It will not happen by itself.

> On a hybrid team, meetings include five people in a conference room and four joining remotely.
>
> Remote members say they cannot follow side conversations, and that decisions are often changed in the corridor after meetings end.

What should the project manager do?

A Require all team members to work from the office on meeting days.

B Stop holding hybrid meetings and use email for all decisions.

C Ask remote members to interrupt more when they cannot hear.

D Agree remote-first meeting norms with the team, and record decisions only in a shared channel.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Everyone in the office.

May be impossible, and overrides the organisation's working arrangements.

B Decide everything by email.

Thin channel for decisions, and loses discussion entirely.

C Remote people interrupt more.

Puts the burden on the disadvantaged group, and changes nothing structural.

D Remote-first norms; decisions in one shared place.

Puts everyone on the same footing and closes the corridor loophole.

THE SIGNAL

Two classes of participant: redesign the meeting so everyone joins the same way, and decide in one place.

> An offshore supplier delivered a reporting feature built to a different interpretation of the requirements. The requirements were agreed on a video call.
>
> English is a second language for most of the supplier's team, and they had confirmed they understood.

What should the project manager do to prevent this happening again?

A. After each requirements call, confirm in writing with examples, and ask the supplier to play back its understanding.

B. Begin looking for a supplier whose team are native English speakers.

C. Hold longer requirements calls to cover every detail.

D. Apply the contract's penalty clause for the incorrect delivery.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do to prevent this happening again?

A Written confirmation, examples, playback.

Turns 'yes, understood' into evidence of understanding, before work starts.

B Switch to native speakers.

Discriminatory in effect, and the problem is the process, not the people.

C Longer calls.

More talk does not create shared understanding. Nothing is checked.

D Apply the penalty.

Punishes a failure the process allowed, and damages the relationship.

THE SIGNAL

'They confirmed they understood' is the planted detail. A yes on a call is not proof of understanding.

Make the unspoken **explicit**: times, channels, norms and understanding.